

VIVRAM SHARMA

qualities of its subject. *Solo* does this with aplomb and precision, bringing alive not just the jangling, playful, arabesque richness of traditional Balkan music (and its contemporary revival under the ambit of "world music" after the collapse of Statist Socialism in Bulgaria) but also the uncanny tinnitus that we could characterise as the "sound" of the 20th century itself.

Solo does something far more significant as well. Just as the written word can only invite us to imagine the sound of music without actually hearing it, such that the sonic experience of music in literature always contains a hidden "utopian" dimension, so too Dasgupta's deployment of music (as a reticent metaphor) also enables him to achieve specific ethical purposes without actually rendering them bland and heavy with bald statement. Music, and what it takes to make it—the dynamics of loudness, softness and sustenance, the struggle to hold or embellish a note or a tone, the constancy of rehearsal and the sense of failure that is built into every search for perfection—also becomes, in the author's tutelage, a moral compass.

We learn about the necessity or redundancy of emphasis and repetition, of figuration and feeling from trying the "sound" of our actions, thoughts and emotions for ourselves. This anticipation of what we might do, or accounting for what has been done, and the actual striking of the "note" of an act can only be done "solo". This is what makes for the inner life of all individuals. When we seek to join our voice to the tumult of the world, we have to also seek ways of listening to ourselves.

Sometimes, even those gifted with perfect pitch realise that their music leaves much to be desired. And their sense of their own failure to sing as they wanted to can be the rehearsal for other, more perfectible melodies. The failure of the 20th century to sing a good song, to live up to its promises, can be the basis for the dream of a new music, another sound, perhaps a different way of living and imagining the world.

Solo is a book eminently of and for our times, a book of big ideas and little stories, as rich and generous as a symphony, as particular and luminous as the rising and falling of a singular voice. Read it, acquire it, share it, hum it, by any means necessary. ■

Change on Wheels

From bankruptcy to cash surplus—how the Indian Railways was transformed

By Shankkar Aiyar



Normally books on the public sector are platforms to rail and rant at inefficiency, misuse and misappropriation. Such is the perception of the public about the public sector or anything owned and managed by the government. And exceptions, if any, only prove the rule that anything owned and managed by the government can and will be run into the ground, sooner than later. Rarely, if ever, do we hear of turnaround stories from the public sector; rarer it is to see a book full of facts that illustrate a story of transformation.

Bankruptcy to Billions by Sudhir Kumar and Shagun Mehrotra is essentially a story of change. It is the story of how the Indian Railways was turned around from being an organisation on the brink of bankruptcy to one that has a cash surplus of over Rs 30,000 crore now. In just four short years, Lalu Yadav spearheaded perhaps the most effective reforms programme in the Government of India. Mind you the Indian Railways is not just any organisation. It runs 13,000 train services using a fleet 8,000 locomotives which haul two lakh wagons and 40,000 coaches using a 63,000-km network to ferry goods and 17 million passengers every day to pay for 1.4 million employees and 1.1 million pensioners. How did they do it? To quote Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, the Indian Railways "leveraged its existing assets, essentially by operating faster, longer and heavier trains". To many, just the transformation is nothing short of a miracle but what is more startling is that this has been done without compromising on the "political need" to keep access to railway services available to the poorest of the poor. Which is why the book is not just the story of the Indian Railways but is the story of the makeover of Lalu Yadav.

Writing about business enterprises can get terribly boring and tedious but Kumar (the mind behind the methodical transformation of the Railways) and Mehrotra have used a combination of anecdotal images and factual analysis to bring home to the reader what would easily be described by history as a wondrous event. The only jarring note, if at all, is that it should be released just before the general elections. ■